

Decision Maker			
You want	A graphics chipset that helps you play an occasional game. Needs to be cheap	A solution that should run most of the games, but price is a consideration	Top-notch performance in both 2D and 3D. Price no bar!
You need	A chipset that will give you a minimum of 60 fps in low resolutions with compromises in visual quality	A chipset that will give you a minimum of 60 fps in medium resolutions with minimum compromises in video quality	You need maximum performance with all the eye candy enabled and with zero compromise in resolution or quality
Look for	Cards based on the nVidia GeForce2 MX200 and the GeForce2 MX400 chipsets	Cards based on the nVidia GeForce2 Ti VX and the GeForce4 MX420 chipsets	Cards based on the ATi Radeon 8500, the nVidia GeForce4 Ti 4200 and the Ti 4600 chipsets
Recommended System	Intel Pentium III 500 MHz, 64 or 128 MB RAM	Intel Pentium III or AMD Athlon 1 GHz, 128 or 256 MB RAM	Intel P4 2.4 GHz or AMD Athlon XP 1700+, 256 or 512 MB RAM
Price range	Rs 2,100 to 7,000	Rs 7,100 to 13,000	Rs 15,750 to 40,000

4 out of 5 in this test. The rest languished at 3, whereas the entire ATi Radeon series scored 4 of 5.

What it all leads to...

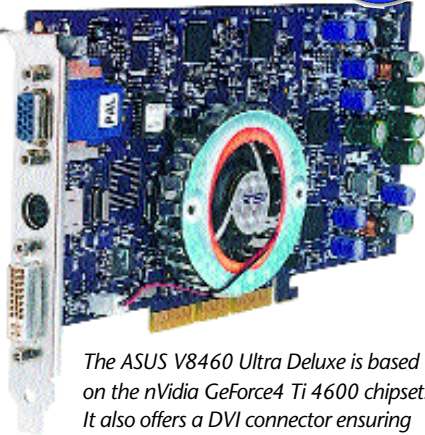
In our test process, we have tried to evaluate every nuance of what makes a good graphics chipset. Decent performance under *Quake III Arena* ensures that your graphics chip will run most current games without a hitch, while *Comanche 4* and 3DMark2001 give a good indication of their performance in future games.

Overall, the results were not very surprising. Older generation chipsets did pretty badly in the high performance tests and are not for someone who is looking for a future-proof buy. The **GeForce2 MX200** comes out on top as our Best Value winner, offering adequate gaming horsepower at a price that is within most people's grasp.

However, if you want the ultimate gaming experience, don't mind the price and wish to be future-proof for a healthy period of time, you should set your eyes on the cards based on the high-end chipsets like the GeForce 4 Ti series and the ATi Radeon 8500. These chipsets feature cutting edge technology that future games will make use of. Playing games at maximum resolutions on the cards based on these chipsets is not a problem at all even if extras like FSAA and anisotropic filtering are enabled. But the truly outstanding performer in our tests was the **GeForce4 Ti 4600**. This beast is truly the fastest graphics chip in the world and wins our Best Performance Award with ease.

Winners!

nVidia GeForce 4 Ti 4600: Fresh out of the nVidia stables, the GeForce4 Ti 4600 is a real power-horse. This chipset is a piece of engineering marvel with very efficient memory architecture, and a core that is DirectX 8 compliant. It can handle current and next generation games at extremely high-resolutions with FSAA and anisotropic filtering turned on, resulting in excellent 3D quality. The fact that the chipset can support a



The ASUS V8460 Ultra Deluxe is based on the nVidia GeForce4 Ti 4600 chipset. It also offers a DVI connector ensuring brilliant image quality on TFTs

maximum of 128 MB of high-speed, on-board DDR memory means that games featuring high-quality textures will run with ease on this chip. This chipset was the clear winner in every test that we ran. It posted an amazing 290.4 fps in *Quake III Arena* at a maximum resolution and quality set-

ting of 1024x768, running at 32-bit colour and with 32-bit textures. It also posted a record-setting score of 10760 3DMarks in 3DMark2001 SE, a benchmark that few chips can conquer. With a card based on this chipset inside your system, you won't have to worry about dropping frame rates when playing current or future games.

nVidia GeForce2 MX200: Based on the venerable GeForce2 chipset, the GeForce2 MX200 is an ideal purchase for those seeking a low-cost solution to their gaming needs. Sporting a twin pixel pipeline, with two texture mapping units per pipe, this chip is architecturally adept at handling all of the current-generation games.

Considering its price, the chipset did very well in our test suite. It



The ASUS GeForce2 MX200 Magic comes with an S-Video Out and is based on the nVidia GeForce2 MX200 chipset

scored an impressive 113.2 fps in *Quake III Arena* at normal quality and managed a decent showing at the high quality setting (with 46.7 fps). 3DMark2001 SE was not very kind to the older generation chipsets but the GeForce2 MX200 received a fairly decent score of 1441 3DMarks. Similarly the *Comanche 4* benchmark managed to humiliate every other low-end solution except for the MX200.

It becomes pretty evident that a card based on this particular chipset would cater very well to the casual gamer. It can run almost all the games that are currently out there at a decent frame rate and if you are into slow-paced games like role-playing or adventures, this chipset will even handle them at a high-resolution.

YATISH SUVARNA and AHMED SHAIKH